בס״ד

# The `shiur` package

Source sheets (*dappei mekorot*) for handouts and slides

Gabriel Gendler Yom-Tov
shiurtex@thm.mozmail.com

Version 2.1, 29 October 2026

## Introduction

`shiur` typesets Jewish source sheets: numbered sources, each in Hebrew with an English translation, with notes for the person giving the class (the *maggid shiur*). From one file of content it can produce:

- a handout for participants (*talmid*), and one with the teacher's notes (*maggid shiur*);
- a bilingual handout and a Hebrew-only one;
- a large-print handout;
- beamer slides, with long sources split over several slides.

Each version is a two- or three-line wrapper file around the shared content, so a correction made once appears in every version.

The package needs XeLaTeX and a font with Hebrew. It loads `polyglossia` (with English as the main language and Hebrew as the other), `geometry`, `fancyhdr`, `framed`, `xcolor` and `hyperref`, among others.

## A first source sheet

```
\documentclass[11pt]{article}
\usepackage{shiur}
\setshiurfont{hebrew}{FreeSerif}

\title{Wheat from the clouds}
\author{A. Teacher}
\date{}

\begin{document}
\maketitle

\begin{mekor}[\bavli{menachot}{69b}]
```

```
\begin{mekorlang}{hebrew}
בעי ר' זירא: חיטין שירדו בעבים מהו?
\end{mekorlang}
\begin{mekorlang}{english}
R. Zeira asked: ``if wheat descended in clouds, what is the law?''
\end{mekorlang}
\end{mekor}

\end{document}
```

`\setshiurfont{hebrew}{...}` chooses the Hebrew font, for handouts and slides alike. Without it, the package picks an installed font itself (see "Fonts"). Every page has בס״ד at the top right, the title page included; `\maketitle` prints the title as usual. The heading, given to the `mekor`, is a reference (see "References"), which comes out in the language of each `mekorlang`.

The source above comes out like this:

**א. בבלי מנחות ס״ט ע״ב**

בעי ר׳ זירא: חיטין שירדו בעבים מהו?

**1. B. Menaḥot 69b**

R. Zeira asked: "if wheat descended in clouds, what is the law?"

## Sources

### `mekor` and `mekor*`

A `mekor` holds one source and gives it the next number. A `mekor*` holds a source that continues the previous one, and takes no new number. On slides, each `mekor` is a frame. The optional argument is the source's heading, printed over each of its languages. A reference there, such as `\tanach{gen}{1:1}`, comes out in each `mekorlang`'s own language, so it is written once.

### `mekorlang`

```
\begin{mekorlang}[subtitle]{language}{title}
  text
\end{mekorlang}
```

The title is optional: without it, the `mekorlang` takes the `mekor`'s heading. Give one when the languages need different headings, as when the heading isn't a reference:

```
\begin{mekor}
\begin{mekorlang}{hebrew}{מנחת אשר, קורונה}
```

```
  ...
\begin{mekorlang}{english}{Min\hdot at Asher, Coronavirus}
```

A title must follow `{language}` directly; text that starts with a brace goes on the next line.

Each language of a source is a `mekorlang`. Hebrew is set right to left with Hebrew numerals, and any other language left to right with arabic numerals. Hebrew has three names, which differ only in font (see "Fonts"): `hebrew` for most text, `mikra` for Tanakh, and `rashi` for text in Rashi script. The number of the source goes in the margin of a handout. The optional subtitle, in italics under the title, usually names the author or the translation:

```
\begin{mekorlang}[\attribution{R. Asher Weiss}{Jerusalem}{5780}]
  {english}{Min\hdot at Asher}
```

`\attribution{who}{where}{when}` joins its non-empty parts with commas, giving "R. Asher Weiss, Jerusalem, 5780".

### Verse numbers

In a passage from Tanakh, `\pasuk` starts each verse with its number, and `\perek` starts a new chapter:

| Command | English | Hebrew |
|---|---|---|
| `\pasuk` | the next verse: (19) | (יט) |
| `\pasuk[23]` | verse 23 of this chapter | (כג) |
| `\pasuk[37:18]` | chapter 37, verse 18 | (לז יח) |
| `\perek{38}` | the start of chapter 38 | (לח א) |

Each `mekorlang` counts from scratch, so the Hebrew and its translation use the same commands and come out numbered alike. Where verses are left out, an ellipsis comes first: going from verse 20 to `\pasuk[23]` gives "... (23)". Moving on to the first verse of the next chapter counts as continuing, since the package can't know where a chapter ends; if you skipped the end of a chapter, use the starred form, `\pasuk*[39:1]` or `\perek*{39}`, which always puts an ellipsis first.

```
\begin{mekorlang}{mikra}{בראשית לז יח-כג; לח א}
\pasuk[37:18] וַיִּרְאוּ אֹתוֹ מֵרָחֹק
\pasuk וְאִישׁ אֶל אָחִיו
\pasuk וְעַתָּה לְכוּ וְנַהַרְגֵהוּ
\pasuk[23] וַיְהִי כַּאֲשֶׁר בָּא יוֹסֵף אֶל אֶחָיו
\perek{38} וַיְהִי בָּעֵת הַהִוא
\end{mekorlang}
```

**ב. בראשית לז יח-כ, כג; לח א**

(לז יח) ׳וַיִּרְאוּ אֹתוֹ מֵרָחֹק (יט) וַיֹּאמְרוּ אִישׁ אֶל אָחִיו (כ) הִנֵּה לכו וְנַהַרְגֵהוּ ... (כג) ׳וַיְהִי כַּאֲשֶׁר בָּא יוֹסֵף אֶל אֶחָיו
(לח א) ׳וַיְהִי בָּעֵת הַהִוא

## 2. Genesis 37:18–20, 23; 38:1

(37:18) They saw him from afar (19) and said to one another (20) “Come now, let us kill him” ... (23) When Joseph came to his brothers (38:1) At that time

On slides, the numbering carries on across a source split with `\mekorbreak`.

### Leaving text out

`\dilug` marks a place where text is left out, in any source, translation or note: `said \dilug Why` gives “said ... Why”. It keeps the ellipsis on the line of the word before it, and it never doubles up: straight before `\pasuk` or `\perek` it stands for the marker’s own ellipsis, and at a `\mekorbreak` it merges with the break’s. So to leave out the end of verse 22 and go on with verse 23, write `\dilug \pasuk`, or `\pasuk*`.

### References

The references in headings come from the `mareimekomot` package, which `shiur` loads and which works in other documents too, such as papers and books. A reference is written once and comes out in the language around it, so a `mekor`’s heading serves all its languages:

| Command | English | Hebrew |
|---|---|---|
| `\tanach{gen}{37:18-20}` | Genesis 37:18–20 | בראשית ל״ז, י״ח–כ׳ |
| `\tanach[rashi]{gen}{18:7}` | Rashi on Genesis 18:7 | רש״י על בראשית י״ח, ז׳ |
| `\bavli{menachot}{69b}` | B. Menaḥot 69b | בבלי מנחות ס״ט ע״ב |
| `\bavli[tosafot]{yoma}{9a}` | Tosafot on B. Yoma 9a | תוספות יומא ט׳ ע״א |
| `\mishnah{sukkah}{4:1}` | M. Sukkah 4:1 | משנה סוכה ד׳, א׳ |
| `\shulchanaruch{oh}{605:1}` | Shulḥan Arukh, Oraḥ Ḥayyim 605:1 | שו״ע או״ח סי׳ תר״ה סע׳ א׳ |
| `\mishnahberurah{605:3}` | Mishnah Berurah 605:3 | משנה ברורה סי׳ תר״ה ס״ק ג׳ |
| `\sefer{tanchuma}{noach}{1}` | Midrash Tanḥuma, Noaḥ 1 | מדרש תנחומא, נח א׳ |
| `\sham[rashi]` | Rashi ad loc | רש״י שם |

Books, tractates and works are named by keys in any usual transliteration (`menachot`, `menakhot` and `menahot` are the same). `\declaresefer` declares any other work from a template, `\declarecommentary` a commentary, and `\declaretursefer` a work arranged by the Tur; a document’s own declaration replaces the package’s. The `mareimekomot` manual (`mareimekomot-doc.pdf`) describes all of it, with the full lists of names.

Two things are particular to `shiur`. On slides, where a source can be several slides from the one it refers to, `\sham` also gives the reference it stands for: “Rashi ad loc (B. Menaḥot 69b)”. And a source whose heading has no reference of the package’s (a work not declared, say) clears `\sham`, so `\sham` after it stays plain rather than pointing at the wrong source.

## Notes

Notes are the maggid shiur's commentary: questions to ask, points to make, transitions. They are printed only in the `maggidshiur` version, beside a grey bar on the side where their lines start.

```
\begin{hearah}
Why does R. Zeira ask about wheat rather than any other food?
\end{hearah}

\begin{hearah}[hebrew]
הערה בעברית.
\end{hearah}
```

> Why does R. Zeira ask about wheat rather than any other food?

> הערה בעברית.

The optional argument is the language of the note, English by default; `hebrew`, `mikra` and `rashi` all give a Hebrew note. A `hearah` can go anywhere: between sources, or inside a `mekor`, before its text to introduce it or after its text to follow it.

Slides leave the notes out, even with `maggidshiur` (the package warns that it ignores the option there): they are shown to everyone, and notes beside the sources would crowd them off the slide. Present with the slides and keep the handout with the notes in front of you.

## Options

| Option | Effect |
|---|---|
| `talmid` | Leave out the notes. This is the default. |
| `maggidshiur` | Print the notes. |
| `translations=false` | Leave out each English `mekorlang` that follows a Hebrew one in the same source. Sources written in English, with no Hebrew before them, stay. |
| `accessible` | Set the handout in large print: 18 pt type, with every other size scaled to match, and unjustified text (ragged right for English, ragged left for Hebrew). Slides are unchanged. |
| `accessible=`*size* | The same, at another size, e.g. `accessible=20pt`. |

When one version needs text that another doesn't, `\iftranslations{A}{B}` typesets $A$ in the bilingual version and $B$ in the Hebrew-only one:

```
\iftranslations{\begin{hearah}A note about the translation.\end{hearah}}{}
```

## One body, several versions

The quickest start is the `newshiur` script in the package's `scripts` folder:

```
newshiur --author "A. Teacher" wheat
```

makes a folder `wheat` holding

- `wheat_body.tex`, the content, with a sample section;
- `wheat.tex`, the participants' handout;
- `wheat_presenter_notes.tex`, the handout with the notes;
- `wheat_beamer.tex`, the slides.

Its options:

**`--hebrew-only`, `--large-print`** add those versions of the handout;

**`--title`, `--author`, `--font`** set the title, the author and the Hebrew font (the title is otherwise made from the name);

**`--here`** puts the files in the current folder rather than a new one.

The environment variables `SHIUR_AUTHOR` and `SHIUR_HEBREW_FONT` give your usual author and font. The title, author and font go at the top of the body, so they are set once for every version. Write the shiur in the body, and compile the wrappers.

The `buildshiur` script, in the same folder, compiles them all at once:

```
buildshiur wheat
```

compiles every wrapper of every body in the folder `wheat` (or, with no folder named, the current one) side by side, each as many times as its bookmarks and slide navigation need. It prints a line for each version: `ok`, or the first error with its file and line. With `--clean` it then deletes the auxiliary files (`.aux`, `.log` and the like) of the versions that built.

The rest of this section explains how the files fit together.

Put everything from `\begin{document}` to `\end{document}` in a body file, and give each version a small file of its own. If the versions differ only in options, the body can hold the whole document, preamble included, and each version passes its options before reading it:

```
% shiur_hebrew.tex
\PassOptionsToPackage{translations=false}{shiur}
\input{shiur_body}
```

```
% shiur_notes.tex
\PassOptionsToPackage{maggidshiur}{shiur}
\input{shiur_body}
```

### Handouts and slides from one body

A handout and a beamer presentation need different document classes, so each keeps its own preamble and reads the body with `\input`. The handout loads `beamerarticle` before `shiur`, so the body can use beamer's commands in both:

```
% shiur.tex: the handout
\documentclass[11pt]{article}
\usepackage{beamerarticle}
\usepackage[talmid]{shiur}
\input{shiur_body}
```

```
% shiur_slides.tex: the presentation
\documentclass{beamer}
\usepackage{shiur}
\input{shiur_body}
```

What every version shares can go at the top of the body, before `\begin{document}`: it is read after each wrapper has loaded the package, so it is still part of the preamble, and a change there reaches every version:

```
% shiur_body.tex
\title{Wheat from the clouds}
\author{A. Teacher}
\date{}
\setshiurfont{hebrew}{FreeSerif}

\begin{document}
\maketitle
...
\end{document}
```

In the body:

- `\mode<presentation>{...}` holds material for the slides only, such as a frame of photographs, and `\mode<article>{...}` material for the handout only;
- `\maketitle` makes a title on the handout and a title frame on the slides.

### Splitting a long source over several slides

A source too long for one slide can be split with `\mekorbreak`, placed at the same point in each language. The handout ignores it and prints the source whole. On the slides, the source stays one frame, with one slide for each part. Every slide repeats the headings, and an ellipsis marks each side of a cut, replacing any punctuation there:

```
\begin{mekor}
\begin{mekorlang}{hebrew}{קיז תהלים}
כָּל־הָאֻמִּים׃ שַׁבְּחוּהוּ כָּל־הָעֻמִּים אֶת־יְהוָה הַֽלְלוּ
\mekorbreak
הַֽלְלוּיָהּ׃ לְעוֹלָם וָאֶמֶת יְהוָה חֶסֶד וְעַל־נוּ גָּבַר כִּי
\end{mekorlang}
\begin{mekorlang}{english}{Psalm 117}
Praise the Lord, all you nations; extol Him, all you peoples.
\mekorbreak
For great is His steadfast love toward us...
\end{mekorlang}
\end{mekor}
```

`\mekorbreak*` splits without the ellipses, where nothing is cut, for example where a question ends and its answer begins.

## Fonts

Hebrew text has three roles, each with its own font:

**`hebrew`** rabbinic and other text, and every role's fallback;

**`mikra`** Tanakh. Its *trop* (cantillation marks) sits beside and among the vowels, and only some fonts position it well;

**`rashi`** text in Rashi script, such as a commentary printed in it.

Choose a role's font in the preamble, with any of `fontspec`'s options before or after the name:

```
\setshiurfont{hebrew}{Frank Ruehl CLM}
\setshiurfont{mikra}{Taamey Frank CLM}
\setshiurfont{rashi}{Noto Rashi Hebrew}
\setshiurfont{mikra}{TaameyFrankCLM}[Path=fonts/, Extension=.ttf,
  UprightFont=*-Medium, BoldFont=*-Bold]
```

A role you don't set gets the first of these fonts that is installed, and the log says which:

| Role | Fonts tried, in order |
|---|---|
| `hebrew` | Taamey Frank CLM, Ezra SIL, Keter YG, Noto Serif Hebrew, FreeSerif |
| `mikra` | Taamey Frank CLM, Taamey David CLM, Ezra SIL, SBL Hebrew, Keter YG |
| `rashi` | Noto Rashi Hebrew |

If none of a role's fonts is installed, `mikra` and `rashi` use the `hebrew` font, and `hebrew` ends with FreeSerif, which comes with TEX Live. Documents that set `\hebrewfont` (or `\hebrewfontsf` in beamer) with `\newfontfamily` keep that font as the `hebrew` one. A `mikra` or `rashi` font that lacks some punctuation, as Rashi fonts often do, borrows it from the `hebrew` font.

The sample sheet `shiur-fonts.pdf`, next to this manual, shows all three roles in use.

### Fonts for trop

A general Hebrew font may have every trop mark and still place them badly, crowding a mark against a vowel or setting it off its letter. Figure 1 shows the same verses in FreeSerif and in Taamey Frank CLM, a font made for trop.

בְּרֵאשִׁית בָּרָא אֱלֹהִים אֵת הַשָּׁמַיִם וְאֵת הָאָרֶץ׃ וְהָאָרֶץ הָיְתָה תֹהוּ וָבֹהוּ FreeSerif

בְּרֵאשִׁית בָּרָא אֱלֹהִים אֵת הַשָּׁמַיִם וְאֵת הָאָרֶץ׃ וְהָאָרֶץ הָיְתָה תֹהוּ וָבֹהוּ Taamey Frank CLM

Figure 1: Genesis 1:1–2 in a general font and in a font made for trop.

So that nobody's source sheet is let down by its fonts without their knowing, the package warns when a `mikra` source with trop is set in a font that isn't known to handle it, unless you chose that font yourself with `\setshiurfont`. The warning appears once per document, among LATEX's warnings, and says what to install. These fonts handle trop well, and are free:

**Ezra SIL** from SIL International (`https://software.sil.org/ezra/`); on Debian and Ubuntu, `sudo apt install fonts-sil-ezra`.

**Taamey Frank CLM** and Taamey David CLM, from the Culmus project (`https://culmus.sourceforge.io`).

**Keter YG** also from Culmus; on Debian and Ubuntu, `sudo apt install fonts-culmus`.

**SBL Hebrew** from the Society of Biblical Literature, free for non-commercial use.

For Rashi script, Noto Rashi Hebrew is part of Google's free Noto fonts.

## Sources of a text

The companion package `teudot`, loaded with `\usepackage{teudot}`, marks the sources (strands) of a text, as in the documentary hypothesis, and shows each copy of a `mekor` in colour, with some strands alone, or with the rest invisible but keeping their space:

```
\declareteudah[name=Yahwist]{j}{blue}
...
\begin{mekor}[\tanach{exodus}{14:19-23}]
\teudotsetup{show=j, others=omit}
\begin{mekorlang}{english}
\pasuk[14:19] \teudah{e} The angel of God moved. \teudah{j} The pillar ...
```

Verse numbers stay in place in every version. Its manual, `teudot-doc.pdf`, describes it.

## Other commands

**`\hdot`, `\Hdot`** ḥ and Ḥ, for transliteration (Ḥanukah).

**`\sectionsymbol`** §.

**`boxedtext`** text in a box, on handouts and slides.

## Licence

Copyright 2023–2026 Gabriel Gendler Yom-Tov. This work may be distributed and/or modified under the conditions of the LaTeX Project Public License, either version 1.3c of this license or (at your option) any later version.